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INDIA PICTURE

THE GOOD FIGHT

The story of India is also a story of inherent inequities. Some individuals and groups showed not just the vision to dream of a better, more just society but also the grit and conviction to build it



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'Bad news on the doorstep'. This phrase from Don McLean's classic song *American Pie* crosses my mind every morning as I pick up the newspaper tossed onto my balcony. Against the daily dose of despair—the downward spiral of public life, the distress of marginalised communities, the devastation of the environment—I feel all the more grateful for these sources of light that dispel the dark; for people who can imagine a better world and have the courage to bring it to life; for citizens who have taken to heart Mahatma Gandhi's talisman of thinking of the poorest and the weakest first, and who have committed to striving for compassion and justice towards others.

India lives in its villages. Six out of every 10 Indians still depend on farm-related work for their livelihood. Yet, such is the relentless grind of rising input costs, uncertain markets and unpredictable weather that many cannot make ends meet. Migrating to cities for work seems to be the only way to ease this reproduction squeeze. This deadlock has been broken by the **Deccan Development Society** (**DDS**) in Telangana and its focus on millets. By helping Dalit women farmers secure land and grow crops eminently suited for drylands, the DDS has enabled them to become debt-free and eat healthier food while being kinder to the planet. In Andhra Pradesh, the **Timbaktu Collective** works in the same spirit by building cooperatives that support villagers' return to organic farming and regenerating forests. Together, they show a way past the cul-de-sac of chemical- and water-intensive farming.

The belief that economy and ecology must work in harmony also inspires the **Sahjeevan Trust** in Kutch, Gujarat.